MODERN INDIA I · DAY 1 OF 6 · TEST ON 31 OCT 2026

Arrival of Europeans and the Early English Wars

Companies, Carnatic Wars, Plassey and Buxar, Mysore and Maratha Wars · mind map · map · timeline

The big picture

Today's test has 50 questions: about 17 on the European companies and about 33 on the wars that gave the English control of India. The whole topic is one story told in four steps.

The logic in one line: Europeans came for trade (1498–1664); the English and French then fought for the south (1746–63); the English alone took Bengal (1757–65), which paid for their wars; and with Bengal's money they beat Mysore (1767–99) and the Marathas (1775–1818).

Step	Years	Who against whom	Result
1 Trade	1498–1664	Portuguese, then English, Dutch, Danes, French	Coastal factories and forts
2 Rivalry for the south	1746–63	English vs French (Carnatic Wars)	French political power ends at Wandiwash
3 Conquest of Bengal	1757–65	Company vs Nawabs	Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764, Diwani 1765
4 Conquest of the rest	1767–1818	Company vs Mysore and the Marathas	Tipu dies 1799; Peshwa ends 1818

Master timeline (memorise the order, not just the dates)

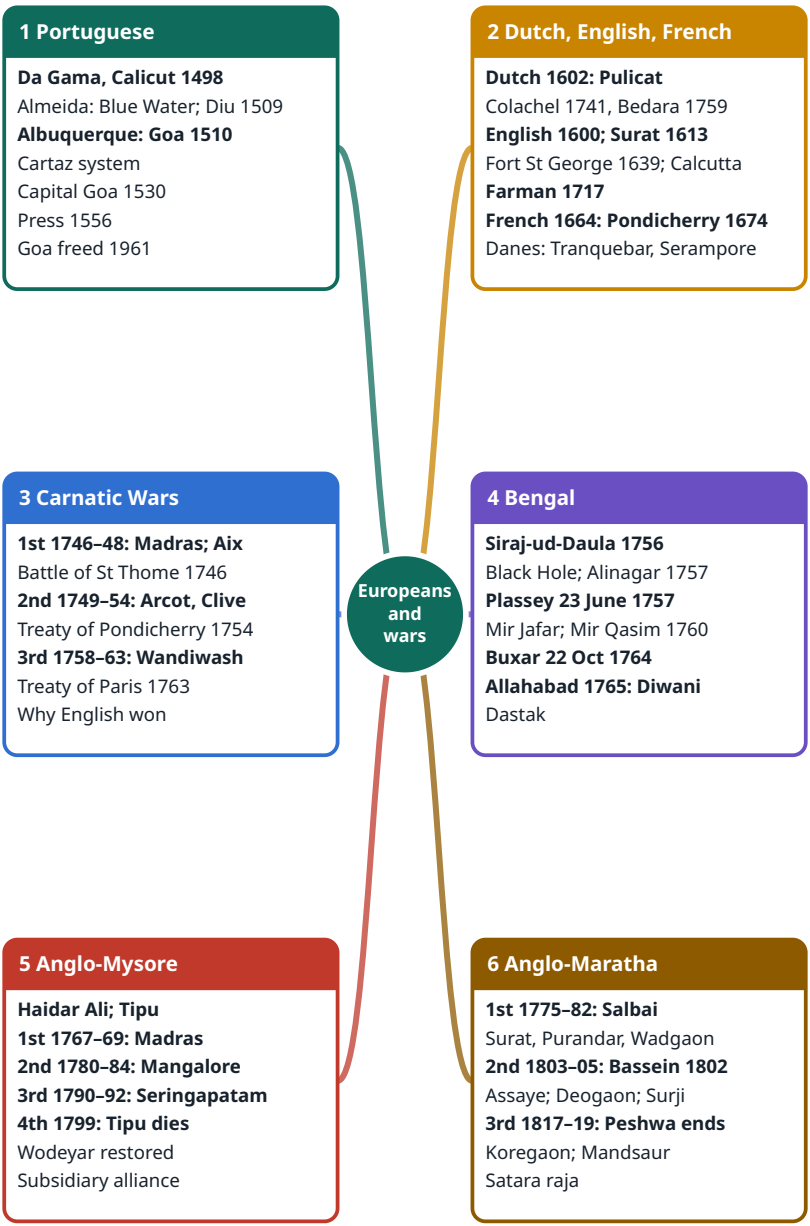
Year	Event	Who
1453	Constantinople falls to the Ottomans	Ottomans
1498	Vasco da Gama lands at Calicut	Portuguese

Year	Event	Who
1509 / 1510	Battle of Diu / capture of Goa	Almeida / Albuquerque
1556	First printing press in India, Goa	Portuguese Jesuits
1600	English Company chartered (31 Dec)	Elizabeth I
1602	Dutch East India Company	Dutch
1608 / 1615	Hawkins at Jahangir's court / Roe	English
1613	Surat factory farman	Jahangir
1639–40	Fort St George, Madras	Francis Day
1664	French Company; Pondicherry 1674	Colbert; Francois Martin
1668	Bombay leased from Charles II	English
1690	Calcutta founded; Fort William 1700	Job Charnock
1717	Farman: free trade in Bengal	Farrukhsiyar
1741	Battle of Colachel	Travancore beats Dutch
1746–48	First Carnatic War; Aix-la-Chapelle	Dupleix, La Bourdonnais
1749–54	Second Carnatic War; Arcot 1751	Clive; Dupleix recalled
1757	Alinagar (Feb); Plassey (23 June)	Clive vs Siraj
1758–63	Third Carnatic War; Wandiwash 1760	Coote vs Lally
1759	Battle of Bedara	English beat Dutch
1764	Battle of Buxar (22 Oct)	Munro
1765	Treaty of Allahabad: Diwani	Clive
1767–69	First Mysore War; Treaty of Madras	Haidar
1775–82	First Maratha War; Salbai	Hastings
1780–84	Second Mysore War; Mangalore	Haidar, Tipu

Year	Event	Who
1790–92	Third Mysore War; Seringapatam	Cornwallis
1799	Fourth Mysore War; Tipu dies (4 May)	Wellesley
1802	Treaty of Bassein (31 Dec)	Peshwa Baji Rao II
1803–05	Second Maratha War	Wellesley, Lake
1817–19	Third Maratha War; Peshwa ends	Hastings (Moira)

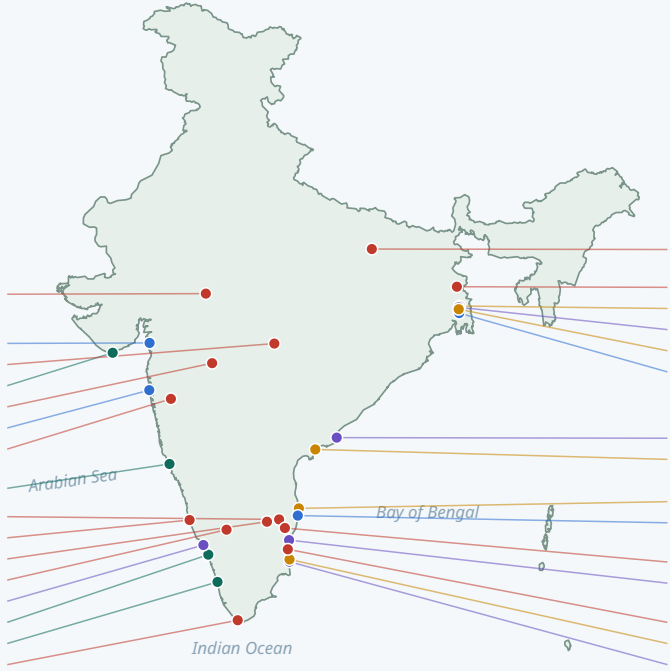
Mind map

Read it in 2 minutes. Six boxes cover today's test.



India map: place, event and year (turn your phone sideways)

Portuguese · Dutch and Danes · English · French · Battle or treaty site



30 **Mahidpur:** Mahidpur 1817

9 **Surat:** English factory 1613
31 **Sitabuldi (Nagpur):** Sitabuldi 1817
4 **Diu:** Battle of Diu 1509
29 **Assaye:** Assaye 1803
10 **Bombay:** Bombay: from Charles II 1668
28 **Pune and Bhima:** Purandar 1776; Wadgaon 1779; Koregaon 1818
3 **Goa:** Albuquerque 1510; press 1556
21 **Arcot:** Arcot: Clive 1751
27 **Mangalore:** Mangalore Treaty 1784
20 **Ambur:** Ambur 1749
25 **Seringapatam:** Seringapatam 1792 and 1799
15 **Mahe:** Mahe: French 1725
1 **Calicut:** Da Gama 1498
2 **Cochin:** Portuguese HQ to 1530; Dutch 1663
8 **Colachel:** Colachel 1741: Dutch beaten

24 **Buxar:** BUXAR 22 Oct 1764
23 **Plassey:** PLASSEY 23 June 1757
7 **Chinsura:** Dutch: Chinsura 1653
14 **Chandernagore:** Chandernagore 1690
19 **Serampore:** Danish: Serampore 1755
12 **Calcutta:** Calcutta: Charnock 1690; Black Hole 1756
16 **Yanam:** Yanam 1731
6 **Masulipatnam:** Dutch 1605; English 1611
5 **Pulicat:** Dutch: Pulicat 1610
11 **Madras:** Fort St George 1639; La Bourdonnais 1746
22 **Wandiwash:** Wandiwash 1760
13 **Pondicherry:** Pondicherry: French 1674; Lally falls 1761
26 **Porto Novo:** Porto Novo 1781
18 **Tranquebar:** Danish: Tranquebar 1620
17 **Karaikal:** Karaikal 1739

READ THE MAP LIKE THIS

- **West coast:** Portuguese (Calicut, Cochin, Goa, Diu); then English Surat and Bombay.
- **East coast:** Dutch Pulicat, English Madras, French Pondicherry, Danish Tranquebar. The Carnatic Wars were fought in this strip (Ambur, Arcot, Wandiwash).
- **Hugli river (Bengal):** English Calcutta, French Chandernagore, Dutch Chinsura, Danish Serampore side by side. Plassey and Buxar lie upriver.
- **South:** Mysore wars at Seringapatam, Mangalore, Porto Novo.
- **West and Deccan:** Maratha wars at Pune, Assaye, Mahidpur, Nagpur.

1. Why Europeans came, and the order of the companies

The Ottoman capture of Constantinople (1453) blocked the old land and Red Sea routes and made spices dearer. Portugal and Spain looked for a sea route. Better ships and the compass helped; Prince Henry of Portugal pushed exploration. Bartolomeu Dias rounded the Cape in 1488 and Vasco da Gama reached Calicut on 20 May 1498. Spices (pepper, cinnamon), cotton cloth, indigo and saltpetre paid for the voyages. The wish to spread Christianity added to the push.

Company	Arrival or formation	First bases	Key people
Portuguese	Da Gama 1498; Estado da India 1505	Calicut, Cochin, Goa 1510	Almeida, Albuquerque, Nino da Cunha
English	Charter 31 Dec 1600	Surat 1613, Masulipatnam 1611, Madras 1639	Hawkins, Roe, Francis Day, Aungier, Charnock

Company	Arrival or formation	First bases	Key people
Dutch	1602	Masulipatnam 1605, Pulicat 1610, Chinsura 1653	Dutch governors; Admiral De Lannoy
Danes	1616	Tranquebar 1620, Serampore 1755	William Carey (Serampore Mission)
French	1664 (Colbert)	Surat 1668, Pondicherry 1674	Francois Martin, Dupleix, Lally

MEMORY HOOK: P-E-D-D-F

Portuguese 1498 → **E**nglish 1600 → **D**utch 1602 → **D**anes 1616 → **F**rench 1664. First to come, last to go: Goa was freed only in 1961.

2. The Portuguese (1498–1961)

- **Almeida (1505–09):** first Viceroy. His "Blue Water" policy meant building sea power instead of land forts. **1509 Battle of Diu:** he beat the Egyptian-Gujarati fleet and made Portugal the master of the Indian Ocean.
- **Albuquerque (1509–15):** captured Goa from Bijapur in **1510**; encouraged Portuguese soldiers to marry local women; Goa became the base.
- **Nino da Cunha (1529–38):** shifted the capital from Cochin to Goa in 1530.
- **Cartaz system:** every Asian ship had to buy a naval pass, or be seized.
- **Culture:** first printing press in India at Goa in 1556; Gothic churches; tobacco, maize, potato, chilli, cashew and pineapple introduced; Garcia de Orta wrote on Indian medicinal plants.
- **Decline:** lost Hugli in 1632 (Shah Jahan), Cochin to the Dutch (1663), Salsette and Bassein to the Marathas (1739). Bombay passed to the English as Catherine's dowry (1661). Goa, Daman and Diu were freed by India in **1961**.

UPSC ANGLE

"Fall of Constantinople encouraged the search for new routes" and "Diu 1509 gave naval supremacy" are both true statements. UPSC asks the governor for each act: Almeida (Blue Water, Diu), Albuquerque (Goa), Nino da Cunha (capital).

MEMORY HOOK

A-A-N: Almeida = Ocean (Diu); Albuquerque = Goa; Nino = Capital to Goa.

3. The Dutch and the Danes

- **Dutch:** United East India Company of the Netherlands (1602). Factories at Masulipatnam (1605), Pulicat (Fort Geldria, 1610), Chinsura (1653), Cochin (1663), Nagapattinam, Kasimbazar, Patna. Their main interest was the spice trade of Indonesia, so India was secondary.
- **1741 Battle of Colachel:** Marthanda Varma of Travancore beat the Dutch; Admiral De Lannoy was captured and served Travancore.
- **1759 Battle of Bedara:** the English (Colonel Forde) beat the Dutch near Chinsura. The Anglo-Dutch Treaty of 1824–25 closed the Dutch chapter in India.
- **Danes:** Tranquebar (1620) and Serampore (1755); the Serampore Mission (Carey, Marshman, Ward) printed books and ran a college. Both settlements were sold to the English in 1845.

SETTLEMENTS QUIZ

French: Pondicherry, Chandernagore, Mahe, Karaikal, Yanam. **Danish:** Tranquebar, Serampore. **Dutch:** Pulicat, Chinsura, Nagapattinam.

4. The English Company: from Surat to Calcutta

Year	Event	Person
1600	Charter by Elizabeth I (31 Dec)	Company of London
1608	Hawkins at Jahangir's court; no farman	William Hawkins
1611	Factory at Masulipatnam	Hippon
1613	Farman allows Surat factory	Jahangir
1615–19	Embassy to the Mughal court	Sir Thomas Roe
1639–40	Fort St George, Madras, from the Raja of Chandragiri	Francis Day
1661–68	Bombay: Portuguese dowry to Charles II (1661); leased to the Company (1668)	Charles II; Gerald Aungier (governor 1669–77) is its real founder
1690	Sutanuti: Calcutta begins; Fort William 1700; zamindari of three villages 1698	Job Charnock
1717	Farman of Farrukhsiyar: free trade in Bengal for Rs 3,000 a year; Bombay mint recognised; duty-free *dastak* power	William Hamilton (surgeon) cured the Emperor

UPSC ANGLE

The 1717 farman is called the "Magna Carta" of the Company. It gave the English trading rights that Indian merchants did not have, and its misuse (dastaks) caused the clash with Murshid Quli, Alivardi and Siraj-ud-Daula.

MEMORY HOOK

H-R-F-C: Hawkins 1608 → Roe 1615 → Francis Day 1639 → Charnock 1690, then the Farman 1717.

5. The French Company (1664–1954)

- **1664:** Colbert (Louis XIV) set up the Compagnie des Indes Orientales. First factory at Surat (Francois Caron, 1668), Masulipatnam (1669).
- **1674:** Pondicherry founded (Francois Martin). Chandernagore 1690; Mahe 1725; Yanam 1731; Karaikal 1739.
- **Dupleix (1742–54)** was the first European to use Indian sepoys in European style and to interfere in the quarrels of the Nawabs. Dumas (1735–41) had earlier won the Nawab's favour.
- After 1763 only trading posts were left; they joined India in 1954 (de facto) and 1962 (de jure).

6. The Carnatic Wars (1746–63): English vs French

The Carnatic Wars were an extension of European wars into India. The Carnatic was the rich coastal territory under the Nawab (Anwaruddin, then Chanda Sahib vs Muhammad Ali), part of the Nizam's Deccan.

War	Years	Cause	Key events	Treaty / result
First	1746–48	War of the Austrian Succession in Europe	La Bourdonnais takes Madras (1746); **St Thome (Adyar) 1746:** a small French force beat the Nawab's big army	**Aix-la-Chapelle 1748:** Madras returned to the English
Second	1749–54	Succession quarrels in Hyderabad (Nasir Jung vs Muzaffar Jung) and Carnatic (Anwaruddin vs Chanda Sahib)	Ambur 1749 (Anwaruddin killed); Clive seizes and holds **Arcot** (1751, 53 days); Chanda Sahib killed 1752	**Treaty of Pondicherry 1754** (Godeheu, after Dupleix's recall). Muhammad Ali Nawab

War	Years	Cause	Key events	Treaty / result
Third	1758–63	Seven Years' War in Europe	Lally for the French; **Wandiwash 22 Jan 1760** (Eyre Coote); Pondicherry falls Jan 1761	**Treaty of Paris 1763:** French posts returned but not fortified

Why the English won

- **Sea power:** the Royal Navy cut French reinforcements.
- **Bengal's revenue** after Plassey paid for the war; French lacked funds.
- **Command:** Clive, Lawrence and Coote worked with the three presidencies; the French quarrelled (Dupleix vs Bussy vs Lally) and Dupleix was recalled.
- **Support at home:** the English government backed its Company; France was busy in Europe.

> **MEMORY HOOK**
> Treaties in order: **A**ix 1748 → **P**ondicherry 1754 → **P**aris 1763 (A-P-P). Battles: **A**mbur 1749 → **A**rcot 1751 → **W**andiwash 1760.

7. Bengal: Plassey, Buxar and Allahabad

Siraj-ud-Daula and Plassey (1756–57)

- **Causes of conflict:** the English fortified Calcutta without permission, misused dastaks (duty-free passes) and sheltered Krishna Das (son of Raj Ballabh), whom the Nawab wanted.
- **June 1756:** Siraj took Calcutta; the "Black Hole" incident (Holwell's account; scale doubted).
- **Jan 1757:** Clive and Watson retook Calcutta; **Treaty of Alinagar (Feb 1757)** restored English privileges. March 1757: Chandernagore taken from the French.
- **Conspiracy:** Mir Jafar, Rai Durlabh, Jagat Seth, Yar Lutuf Khan; Omichand was cheated by a false (red) treaty.

- **Plassey, 23 June 1757:** only Mir Madan and Mohan Lal fought for the Nawab; the commanders held back. Siraj fled and was killed.
- **Result:** Mir Jafar became Nawab; the Company got the zamindari of the 24 Parganas and large payments.

Mir Qasim and Buxar (1760–64)

- **1760:** Mir Qasim replaced Mir Jafar (Vansittart); ceded **Burdwan, Midnapore and Chittagong**.
- He reformed finance and army, moved to Munger and in **1763 abolished internal duties** so that English and Indian traders paid alike.
- War followed: Katwa, Giria, Udhua Nala (1763). Mir Qasim fled to Awadh and allied with **Shuja-ud-Daula** and **Shah Alam II**.
- **Buxar, 22 Oct 1764:** Hector Munro defeated the three allies.

Treaty of Allahabad (Aug 1765)

With	Terms
Shah Alam II	**Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa** to the Company; he got Kora and Allahabad and an annual Rs 26 lakh
Shuja-ud-Daula	Awadh returned; Rs 50 lakh indemnity; Awadh kept as a buffer state
Nawab Najm-ud-Daula	Nizamat left to him with an allowance of Rs 53 lakh

UPSC ANGLE

Plassey gave political power through treachery; Buxar gave military supremacy; Allahabad gave legal and financial control. Many historians call Buxar more decisive than Plassey. Plassey = Clive; Buxar = Munro.

MEMORY HOOK

Alinagar → Plassey → Mir Qasim → Buxar → Allahabad: 57, 57, 60, 64, 65. "Clive wins Plassey by cheating; Munro wins Buxar fairly; Allahabad gets the Diwani."

Linkage: Plassey gave a puppet Nawab → Mir Qasim tried to be free → Buxar → Allahabad Diwani → Dual Government (Day 2) → 1770 famine → Regulating Act 1773.

8. The Anglo-Mysore Wars (1767–99)

Haidar Ali rose from soldier to Faujdar of Dindigul (1755), built an arsenal with French help and seized Mysore from the Wodeyars in 1761. His son **Tipu Sultan** (reigned 1782–99) modernised Mysore (rockets, a navy plan, new calendar and coins, state trading depots) and sent missions to France, Turkey and Persia.

War	Years	Cause	Key events	Treaty / result
First	1767–69	The English, Nizam and Marathas allied against Haidar; the Nizam defected	Haidar reached the walls of Madras	**Treaty of Madras 1769:** mutual return of conquests and a promise of help
Second	1780–84	English failed to help Haidar against the Marathas as promised and attacked Mahe, a French port in his lands (Hastings)	Porto Novo 1781 (Coote beat Haidar); Haidar died 7 Dec 1782; Tipu fought on	**Treaty of Mangalore 1784:** mutual restoration
Third	1790–92	Tipu attacked Travancore (English ally)	Cornwallis led the army; Marathas and Nizam helped; Seringapatam besieged	**Treaty of Seringapatam 1792:** half his lands, Rs 3.3 crore, two sons as hostages
Fourth	1799	Tipu refused the Subsidiary Alliance and sought French help	General Harris and Arthur Wellesley; **Tipu died 4 May 1799**	Kanara, Coimbatore, Wynad annexed; Wodeyars restored (Krishnaraja III)

MEMORY HOOK

Treaties 69, 84, 92: **M-M-S** (Madras, Mangalore, Seringapatam). Governors: Second War = Hastings; Third = Cornwallis; Fourth = Wellesley.

EXAM TRAPS

- Treaty of Madras ended the Second War. (No: the First.)
- Tipu died in the Third War. (No: Fourth, 1799.)
- Mangalore 1784 was the one that Tipu signed with Cornwallis. (No: with the Madras government, under Hastings.)

9. The Anglo-Maratha Wars (1775–1818)

War	Years	Cause	Key events	Treaty / result
First	1775–82	Succession: Raghunath Rao (Raghoba) vs infant Peshwa Madhav Rao II (Nana Phadnavis)	**Surat 1775** (Bombay and Raghoba); **Purandar 1776** (Calcutta Council, annulled Surat); **Wadgaon 1779** (English defeated by Mahadji Scindia)	**Salbai 1782** (Scindia mediator): Madhav Rao II recognised; Raghoba pensioned; Salsette stays English; 20 years of peace
Second	1803–05	Baji Rao II accepted the Subsidiary Alliance in the **Treaty of Bassein, 31 Dec 1802**; Scindia, Bhonsle and Holkar resisted	Assaye 1803 (Arthur Wellesley); Lake takes Delhi	**Deogaon** (Bhonsle) and **Surji-Anjangaon** (Scindia) Dec 1803; Holkar 1805

War	Years	Cause	Key events	Treaty / result
Third	1817–19	Lord Hastings' Pindari campaign; Peshwa wanted freedom	**Poona 1817** (Peshwa gives up leadership); Kirkee, Sitabuldi (Nov 1817); **Mahidpur 21 Dec 1817**; **Koregaon 1 Jan 1818** (Mahar soldiers of the Company)	**Mandsaur Jan 1818** (Holkar); Peshwa surrenders to Malcolm; Peshwaship abolished; Satara state created

MEMORY HOOK

First War: **S-P-W-S** (Surat, Purandar, Wadgaon, Salbai). Second War: **Bassein** (Peshwa), **Deo**gaon (Bhonsle), **Surji** (Scindia). "Maratha power ended at Mandsaur and Koregaon, 1818."

EXAM TRAPS

- Bassein was signed by Scindia. (No: the Peshwa.)
- Deogaon was signed by Holkar. (No: Bhonsle.)
- Mandsaur was signed by the Peshwa. (No: Holkar.)

Linkage: Wellesley's Subsidiary Alliance (Bassein) pulled the Peshwa under the Company → the Second War → Hastings' Pindari campaign → the Third War → the Peshwa ends, 1818.

10. Treaty master table

Treaty	Year	Between
Aix-la-Chapelle	1748	English and French (1st Carnatic)
Pondicherry	1754	Godeheu and the English
Alinagar	Feb 1757	Siraj-ud-Daula and Clive
Allahabad	1765	Clive, Shah Alam II, Shuja-ud-Daula
Madras	1769	Haidar Ali and the English

Treaty	Year	Between
Purandar	1776	Calcutta Council and the Peshwa
Salbai	1782	English and Marathas
Mangalore	1784	Tipu and the English
Seringapatam	1792	Tipu and Cornwallis
Bassein	31 Dec 1802	Peshwa and Wellesley
Deogaon / Surji-Anjangaon	Dec 1803	Bhonsle / Scindia
Poona	June 1817	Peshwa and Elphinstone
Mandsaur	Jan 1818	Holkar and the English

11. Chronological order at a glance

- **1498** Da Gama, Calicut
- **1510** Goa
- **1600** English Company
- **1602** Dutch
- **1639** Madras
- **1664** French
- **1690** Calcutta
- **1717** Farman
- **1746–63** Carnatic Wars
- **1757** Plassey
- **1764** Buxar
- **1765** Diwani
- **1767–99** Mysore Wars
- **1775–1818** Maratha Wars

EXAM TRAPS

- Clive won Buxar. (No: Munro.)
- Plassey gave the Diwani. (No: Allahabad 1765.)
- Dupleix signed the Treaty of Pondicherry. (No: Godeheu.)
- Albuquerque moved the capital to Goa. (No: he took Goa; Nino da Cunha moved the capital.)
- The first printing press was set up by the English. (No: Portuguese, Goa 1556.)
- Colachel 1741: Dutch beat Travancore. (No: the reverse.)

Sources: Spectrum, *A Brief History of Modern India*; Bipan Chandra; standard coaching notes; question set T3-01. Written in my own words for study. Dates for minor items vary slightly between books. Map outline: Datameet composite India boundary, simplified; pins are approximate.